

Dacian Lamb Pie — Millet as the Sponge, Baked Under the Bell

Knife-chopped lamb salted an hour ahead, soaked sheep's cheese and scalded millet in a wholemeal butter crust, baked covered then open — the millet drinks the juice, so the base stays crisp and the slice stands. A reconstruction from Dacian excavations, not a recovered recipe.

Yield: 2 × 28 cm (12 wedges) Active: 1 hr 10 Total: 3 hr 30 Oven: 220→200°C (425→400°F) Done: 80°C centre

WHERE IT WAS BORN

Dacia, 1st century BC to 106 AD — *reconstructed*. The larder is excavated: bread wheat at Sarmizegetusa Regia, garlic cloves, millet cooked wet at Șimleu Silvaniei; the Greeks mocked the Thracians as *butter-eaters*.

EATEN, AUTHENTICALLY

No Dacian pie survives; the words came with Rome. *Plăcintă* is Latin *placenta*, *fest* is *testum*: Cato's sheep's-cheese pie, baked on a hot hearth under a heated clay bell, coals on top.

HOW IT'S USED NOW

Plăcintă and the *fest* are still Romanian. Here: two round pies for the guests, the same filling as a lidded slab for the crew.

INGREDIENTS

WEIGHT (LB/OZ) · CUPS / VOLUME IN RIGHT COLUMN

START FIRST — THE CHEESE

Brined sheep's cheese 14.1 oz 2½ cups crumbled
(*telemea* or *sheep's feta*, in the piece)

THE FILLING — ABOUT 5½ LB

Lamb shoulder, boned 3 lb 8.4 oz
(from ~2.2 kg on the bone, fat on)

Fine sea salt (*for the lamb*) 0.7 oz ¾ tsp

Garlic (*grated*) 1.1 oz 8 cloves

Hulled proso millet (*rinsed clear*) 5.6 oz ¾ cup + 1 tbsp

Butter (*to toast the millet*) 1.4 oz 3 tbsp

Water, boiling (*for the millet*) 5.6 oz ¾ cup

THE CRUST — TWO PIES

Wholemeal wheat flour (*stone-ground; half strong white if it cracks*) 1 lb 10.5 oz 6 cups

Fine sea salt 0.4 oz 1¼ tsp

Water 12 oz 1½ cups + 1 tbsp

Butter (*diced*) 7.9 oz 1 cup

TO FINISH

Melted butter (*pans and lids*) 1.1 oz 2 tbsp

THE RATIO — LAMB = 100% · FLOUR = 100%

Filling: lamb 100% · soaked cheese 25% · millet 10% dry, scalded 1:1 · garlic 2% · salt 1.25%.
Crust: wholemeal flour 100% · boiling water 45% · butter 30% · salt 1.5%. Millet is sized to the meat, where the juice comes from; the cheese brings its own salt.

Kit: two heavy 28 cm pans, 4 cm deep (cast iron or deep tins) + two more to upturn as lids, or foil · baking steel or heavy tray · sharp knife · clean cloth · rolling pin · probe thermometer · scale

METHOD

- Soak the cheese.** 3 cm pieces, 3x their volume of cold water, fridge **2 h**, water changed twice. A crumb should taste milky, lightly salted. Squeeze hard in a cloth; crumble to 1 cm.
Salt diffuses back out into fresh water; small pieces and changed water keep it moving. — Cato, De Agri Cultura 76
- Chop and salt the lamb.** Sinew and thick fat seams out; 1 cm strips, then **5–8 mm** pieces. Work in the 20g salt and the garlic by hand 2 min, until tacky. Cover, fridge **1 h** (up to 24 h).
Salt draws out myosin, which sets on heating into the bind that lets a filling slice. — Offer & Trinick 1983; Ruusunen & Puolanne 2005
- Scald the millet.** Toast it in the 40g butter, medium heat, **3–4 min**, until nutty and the first grains pop. Add the 160g boiling water, stir once, lid on, off the heat **10 min**. Spread to cool. It should taste underdone.
Proso millet starch gelatinises at 71.5–79°C; lamb collagen shrinks and sheds juice at 53–63°C. Scalded, the grain goes in thirsty and finishes on the juice. — Li et al. 2020; Tornberg 2005
- Fill and close.** Mix lamb, cold millet and cheese until even. Fry a walnut of it; taste; adjust salt. Butter the pans, line with the bases (overhang on), **~1.2 kg filling a pie**, pressed level and firm, no air. Lid on, fold the overhang over, crimp. **1 cm steam hole**; brush with butter.
- Bake under the bell, then open.** Oven **220°C** (fan 200) with a steel on the lowest shelf, 20 min. Pies on the steel, an upturned pan or tight foil dome over each: **30 min**. Uncover, **200°C** (fan 180), **25–35 min**, until the lid is deep brown and the centre reads **80°C**.
Covered it steams and heats through from the hot steel; open, the lid dries and browns. 71°C makes minced lamb safe; 80°C finishes the millet. — Cato 76; USDA FSIS
- Rest, then cut.** **20 min** in the pans on a rack; six wedges a pie (eight for a guest lunch).

The hot-water butter crust — make it after step 3, roll it warm

- Flour and salt in a bowl. Bring the 340g water and 225g butter to a full boil together; pour over; mix, then knead 1 min while hot.
- Cover, rest 15 min, still warm. One 660g piece a pie: 380g rolled to a 34 cm base, 280g to a 29 cm lid, ~4 mm.
- Cold, it cracks: keep it covered, work fast, patch tears with a pinch of dough.

Done: lid deep brown, dry, hollow when tapped · **80°C** (176°F) through the steam hole · juice at the vent thick and glossy, not thin and pink.

Serve: warm, after the 20-min rest — cut hot and the slice slumps.

ONE FILLING, TWO DISHES — THE CREW SLAB

Lamb neck or mutton, chopped and salted the same; millet up to **12%** of the meat. Deep buttered 2/3 GN (or a ~35 × 30 cm tin), **no base**, half the crust as a lid tucked inside the rim, steam holes every 10 cm. Same bake to 80°C; rest 20 min; twelve squares. *Half the pastry, the same slice.*

ELEVATION

TIER 1 — NO EXTRA TIME

- Bay leaves under the base** — Cato set his *placenta* on them
- Flaky salt** — on the buttered lid before the bake

TIER 2 — WORTH IT

- Dried plums** — 150g chopped through the filling
- The Roman finish** — 20g honey on the hot lids

TIER 3 — SERVICE

- A clay fest** — heated on the steel, set over the pie
- Dill + lovage** — the modern Romanian table, not Dacian

TROUBLESHOOT

Puddle, soggy base	Too little millet, wet cheese, cut early → 10% millet, squeeze dry, rest 20 min
Gritty millet	Went in raw, or centre under 80°C → scald it; bake to 80
Slice crumbles	No salting time, lamb too lean → 1 h with the salt, keep the fat
Too salty	Cheese not soaked → 2 h, three waters; fry-test before closing
Dough cracks	It cooled → roll warm, covered; patch with a pinch
Lid pale, base dark	Covered too long → uncover at 30 min; up a shelf for the last 10

CHARTER PREP & STORAGE

Day before	Soak + squeeze the cheese; chop + salt the lamb; both covered at ≤4°C
Crust	On the day; or line the pans and chill, covered, up to 24 h
Raw pies	Freeze in the pans 1 month; thaw overnight; +10 min under the bell
Baked	Fridge within 2 h, 3 days; reheat covered at 180°C to 74°C centre
Provisioning	Millet keeps months sealed, brined cheese in its brine; lamb last port
Never	Close the pie untasted, skip the scald, or cut it straight from the oven